The Old Testament in its World

Class Syllabus: 2026/2027 Season
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I. Course Description: An introduction and overview to the Old Testament/Hebrew Bible with attention to its literary structure, historical and ancient Near Eastern context, and theological themes. Special focus is given to the character of God and the messianic hope demonstrated throughout the Hebrew Bible. Consideration is given to broader Ancient Near Eastern literature, the interpretation and implications of biblical law, prophecy, and wisdom literature, and the relevance of the Hebrew Bible for contemporary Christian life.

II. Class Objectives

1. Identify the major divisions, literary genres, and overarching meta-narrative of the Hebrew Bible, reciting each of the books of the Hebrew Bible in order.
2. Explain how both the character of God and the theme of the Messiah is revealed throughout the Hebrew Bible.
3. Analyze the literary structure and themes of each of the books of the Hebrew Bible.
4. Develop a working knowledge of the ancient Near Eastern world and presumed cultural norms shared by the biblical authors and their audiences which informed the shaping and interpretation of the Hebrew Bible.
5. Defend the Hebrew Bible as Christian Scripture with continued relevance to Christian life across each of its books in all of its literary genres.

III. Class and Reading Structure

Each week of this class will have three components that we'll all participate in together.

1. Attend Sunday morning sessions where we'll explore the content, structure, and context of each book in the Hebrew Bible as well as its various literary genres.
2. Watch BibleProject book overview(s) for the week's book(s).
3. Read the assigned Scripture reading based on your preferred track (see section IV below) and be prepared to discuss it book club–style at the start of class.

IV. Weekly Schedule

Wk	Date	Topic	BP Overview Video
1	8/16	Class Introduction Introduction to the Hebrew Bible	TaNaK/Old Testament
2	8/23	Worldbuilding and Worldview	
3	8/30	Genesis	Genesis 1–11 Genesis 12–50
4	9/13	Exodus, pt 1 Biblical Law	Exodus 1–18
5	9/20	Exodus, pt 2 Leviticus	Exodus 19–40 Leviticus
6	9/27	Numbers	Numbers
7	10/11	Deuteronomy	Deuteronomy
8	10/18	Deuteronomistic History Joshua	Joshua
9	10/26	Judges	Judges
10	11/8	Samuel	1 Samuel 2 Samuel
11	11/15	Kings	1 & 2 Kings
Winter Break			
12	1/10	Prophetic Literature (*Corpus Propheticum*)	
13	1/17	Isaiah	Isaiah 1–39 Isaiah 40–66
14	1/24	Jeremiah	Jeremiah
15	1/31	Ezekiel	Ezekiel 1–33 Ezekiel 34–48
16	2/14	The Twelve	Hosea[1]

[1] If you are running the ultramarathon, you might wish to watch the overview for each of the Books of the Twelve.

Wk	Date	Topic	BP Overview Video
17	2/21	The Ketuvim Biblical Poetry	
18	2/28	Psalms	Psalms
19	3/14	Wisdom Literature Proverbs	Proverbs
20	3/21	Job	Job
21	4/11	The Megilloth Song of Songs	Song of Songs
22	4/18	Ruth	Ruth
23	4/25	Lamentations Ecclesiastes	Lamentations Ecclesiastes
24	5/9	Daniel	Daniel
25	5/16	Esther	Esther
26	5/23	Ezra-Nehemiah Chronicles	Ezra-Nehemiah 1 & 2 Chronicles

V. Reading Schedule

To maximize participation and get everyone reading the text, there are four tracks you can take based on your interest and your capacity. For some this might be a gentle invitation into the text as you read in community, for others, this might be the kick in the pants you needed to read it the whole way through. Each track is designed with slightly different goals, each with an expected weekly time commitment. Each of them are meant to keep us roughly on the same page with one another.

- **5k**: 25 minute weekly commitment; designed for folks who want to get a sample from each book, but don't have the capacity to read more. This will give you an interesting story to connect with the book itself and something worth discussing during our discussion time each week. You will complete **50 biblical stories** in this track.
- **10k**: 1 hour weekly commitment; designed for folks who want to read a few biblical books start to finish, but don't have the capacity to read the whole Old Testament in one shot. Because this will span weeks where other tracks are in other books, it might be worthwhile to occasionally read from the 5k track in addition to your 10k track reading. You will complete **8 biblical books** in this track.

- **Marathon**: 5 hour weekly commitment (mostly aligned with weeks we meet); designed for folks who want to read as much of the Old Testament in one shot as is reasonable. Weeks with especially long books or more than one book being covered will often be reduced or whole books skipped in this track. You will complete **22 biblical books** (out of 39) in this track.
- **Ultramarathon**: 5+ hour weekly commitment (includes some weeks we do not meet); designed for folks who want to read the entirety of the Old Testament by May 2027. You will read the **entire Hebrew Bible** (39 books) in this track.

Week of	5k	10k	Marathon	Ultramarathon
8/16	Gen 2–3	Gen 1–11	Gen 1–11	Gen 1–11
8/23	Gen 12–13	Gen 12–26	Gen 12–26	Gen 12–26
8/30	Gen 37–39	Gen 27–50	Gen 27–50	Gen 27–50
9/13	Exo 3–4 Exo 12, 14	Deut 1–11	Exodus	Exodus
9/20	Lev 16 Lev 19	Deut 12–18	Leviticus	Leviticus
9/27	Num 13–14 Num 22, 24	Deut 19–26	Numbers	Numbers
10/11	Deut 6–8	Deut 27–34	Deuteronomy	Deuteronomy
10/18	Jos 6–7 Jos 24	1 Sam 1–12	Joshua	Joshua
10/26	Jdg 4–5	1 Sam 13–20	Judges	Judges
11/8	1 Sam 24 2 Sam 6–8	1 Sam 21–31	1 & 2 Samuel	1 & 2 Samuel
11/15	1 Kgs 3 1 Kgs 19	1 Kgs 1–3 2 Kgs 17–25	1 Kgs 1–2 Kgs 8 2 Kgs 17–25	1 & 2 Kings
Winter Break				
1/10	Isaiah 6–8	Isaiah 6–8	Isaiah 1–39	Isaiah 1–39
1/17	Isaiah 40 Isaiah 53	Hosea	Isaiah 40–66	Isaiah 40–66

Week of	5k	10k	Marathon	Ultramarathon
1/24	Jer 28–29	Hosea	Jer 1–7 Jer 26–45	Jeremiah
1/31	Ezekiel 1–3	Hosea	Ezekiel	Ezekiel
2/7	*N/A*	*N/A*	*N/A*	Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah
2/14	Jonah	Hosea	Hosea, Habakkuk	Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk
2/21	Psalm 22	Psalms 1–7	Psalms 1–41	Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi
2/28	Psalm 45 Psalm 148	Psalms 51–60	Psalms 42–89	Psalms 1–89
3/7	*N/A*	*N/A*	Psalms 90–150	Psalms 90–150
3/14	Proverbs 8	Songs 1–3	Proverbs	Proverbs
3/21	Job 1–2 Job 41–42	Songs 4–7	Job 1–10 Job 38–42	Job
4/11	Song of Songs 1	Songs 8–14	Song of Songs	Song of Songs
4/18	Ruth	Ruth	Ruth	Ruth
4/25	Lamentations 4	Ezra 1–6	Lamentations	Ecclesiastes Lamentations
5/2	*N/A*	*N/A*	*N/A*	Esther
5/9	Esther 3–7	Ezra 7–10	Esther	Daniel
5/16	Daniel 1–3	Nehemiah 1–7	Daniel	Ezra-Nehemiah
5/23	Nehemiah 1	Nehemiah 8–13	Ezra-Nehemiah 2 Chr 36:15–23	Chronicles